

Supporting a Partner With Arthritis: A Practical Handbook

Small daily acts that ease pain and protect relationships.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Small daily acts that ease pain and protect relationships.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]/community-hub](#)). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews consistently highlight the benefit of early and sustained intervention for managing arthritis. These interventions aren't just about medication; they encompass a holistic approach. Clinical guidelines from leading rheumatology bodies across the UK reinforce the importance of patient education, self-management strategies, and tailored physical activity programmes alongside pharmaceutical treatments.

Randomised controlled trials underscore the positive impact of regular, appropriate exercise on pain reduction, joint function, and overall quality of life for people living with various forms of arthritis. The evidence suggests that even seemingly small, daily acts of support from a partner can significantly contribute to adherence to these beneficial lifestyle changes, thereby improving health outcomes and reducing the burden of the condition.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Ignoring early symptoms:** Don't wait for severe pain; seek advice as soon as you notice persistent joint issues. * **Overdoing it on good days:** Balance activity with rest to prevent flare-ups; pacing is key. * **Stopping medication when feeling better:** Adhere to your prescribed treatment plan consistently unless advised otherwise by your healthcare provider. * **Relying solely on quick fixes:** Understand that arthritis management is a long-term journey, not a short sprint. * **Not communicating openly with your partner:** Share your good days and bad days to help them understand how best to support you.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While routine monitoring is part of living with arthritis, certain changes warrant prompt attention from your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist. Do not delay seeking medical advice if you experience any of the following:

* New and unexplained joint swelling that lasts more than a few days. * Sudden, severe increase in pain in one or more joints. * Signs of infection, such as redness, warmth, or fever around a joint. * Rapid loss of movement or function in a joint. * New symptoms affecting other parts of your body, like persistent rash or breathing difficulties.

Frequently Asked Questions

How can I explain my arthritis pain to my partner so they truly understand? Try to use analogies that relate to their experiences, like comparing it to a deep ache after a marathon or constant toothache. Explain how it affects simple daily tasks and how it can fluctuate, even hourly. Being open and honest about your feelings, rather than just the physical pain, can also help them empathise.

What are some simple ways my partner can help me around the house without making me feel helpless? Your partner can help by taking on tasks that put strain on your joints, such as lifting heavy items, opening stubborn jars, or reaching high shelves. They could also help prepare meals or assist with household chores during a flare. The key is to communicate what you need without feeling like a burden, and to appreciate their efforts.

Is it OK to have sex when I have arthritis pain? Intimacy is important for relationships, and arthritis doesn't mean you have to stop. Communicate openly with your partner about what feels comfortable and what doesn't. You might find certain positions or times of day are better, perhaps after medication or a warm bath. Experimenting together and focusing on closeness can help maintain intimacy.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about supporting a partner with arthritis: a practical handbook?

Short answer: The post says partners can support someone with arthritis through small daily acts, open communication and practical help with joint-straining tasks. It stresses clinician-led, personalised care combining medication, regular comfortable movement, symptom tracking and lifestyle support. It advises pacing, not stopping prescribed treatment, avoiding quick fixes, and seeking prompt review for swelling, fever, severe pain or rapid loss of function.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team

promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk